

4.9a

Chairing: managing the discussion

Worksheet

- A** Jurgen is not speaking in the meeting, although the topic is relevant to him. Which of these comments do you think would encourage him to speak, and which would not?

- 1 Jurgen, you've been very quiet. What do you think?
- 2 Jurgen, after we've heard from Rosa can we have your views? I know you have some experience of this problem.
- 3 I think that's an excellent idea. What do you think, Jurgen?
- 4 Your opinion would be valuable, Jurgen. How do you feel about this?

- B** The table below shows techniques that a chairperson can use to manage the discussion. Complete the table with words from the box.

So consider reaction to view on mean by Are you saying in favour
go over go round the table a little more specific to approach this against

Asking for opinions	What's your (1) _____ that, Carlos? What's your (2) _____ this, Neela?
Asking for clarification	I don't understand. Can you be (3) _____ ? I'm sorry, what do you (4) _____ 'a small problem'?
Using your own words to check	Let me see if I understand. (5) _____ ... ? Sorry, do you mean that ... ?
Summarizing	(6) _____, can I just summarize what we've discussed so far? John, can we just (7) _____ your objections again?
Widening the discussion	Is there anything else we should (8) _____ ? What other ways are there (9) _____ ?
Checking everyone agrees	Does everyone agree that we ... ? Can we (10) _____ to see if everyone agrees? All those (11) _____ ? And all those (12) _____ ?

- C** Look at these six situations. You are the chairperson. Think of a question you could use to manage the discussion in each case. Write your answers using phrases from section B.

- 1 Lee has mentioned 'process reengineering' and one or two people look confused.

- 2 Pamela has suggested that the new product is launched in July. You are not sure if everyone agrees.

- 3 The discussion is going well, but Olga hasn't said anything. The topic is relevant to her.

- 4 There seems to be agreement among the people who have spoken, but you think there may be other ideas.

- 5 There has been a long discussion about possible problems in the manufacturing process.

- 6 Mike is explaining that your main customer is having serious financial difficulties.
